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AI



Why Dispo's co-founder
made the leap from
social media to
steelmaking



Daniel Liss, co-founder of the social network Dispo and the dating app Tease AI, is convinced he's onto the next big thing: steelmaking.

It all started, incongruously, with [a few op-eds](#) he wrote for TechCrunch about anti-trust enforcement in social media.

The commentaries apparently caught the attention of some folks in Washington, D.C., Liss told TechCrunch, and resulted in him being invited to guest judge a war game capstone exercise in spring 2023 hosted by the National War College. The war game was very *au courant*, running a scenario in which the U.S. and China fought for supremacy over Taiwan and the South China Sea.

IMAGE CREDITS: MONTY RAKUSEN / GETTY IMAGES

Liss' take away from the exercise? "Our core supply chain of the arsenal of democracy — literally, the ships that my grandfather fought in — we don't have the ship-building capacity. If we did, we don't have the steel to make it," he said.

At that point, Liss said he became "really interested — obsessed, even" with the steel supply chain. "That was really the birth of Nemo Industries."

The basic pitch for [Nemo Industries](#), Liss' latest startup, appears as though it were drawn from a Venn diagram of two very American anxieties, steelmaking and AI. The company, until now, has

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been operating in stealth, but Liss gave TechCrunch a peek behind the scenes.

First, the obvious part: Nemo will use AI to optimize the production of pig iron, modernizing an industry that Liss said is woefully outdated. “These plants are run on, at best, Excel spreadsheets. At worst, clipboard technology,” he said. The people who run them have “unbelievable expertise,” he added, but that’s the sort of thing that doesn’t scale well.



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But Liss isn’t pitching Nemo as just another piece of industrial software. Rather, Nemo is planning to build its own furnaces. The decision was driven by Liss’ conviction that companies that use AI from inception will have a “20% to 30% margin advantage” over competitors.

In steelmaking, such conviction doesn’t come cheap. Hyundai Motor Group said in March that it would build a \$6 billion steel plant in Louisiana to supply its factories in the U.S. Nemo’s plant may not cost that much since its operations will be focused

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on pig iron, an intermediate product that steelmakers use to make a range of different alloys.

Nemo will fire its furnaces using natural gas, which releases less carbon dioxide than coal, which is commonly used in the iron and steel industry. Liss said the company is considering capturing the furnaces' carbon pollution; tax incentives introduced under the Inflation Reduction Act remain largely intact, and they make the endeavor profitable for Nemo, he said.

Liss' partner in Nemo is Michael DuBose, an investor who previously worked at Cheniere Energy, a natural gas company. "He's built billions of dollars in LNG infrastructure," Liss said.

The startup will need that sort of scale if it's to succeed. Nemo previously raised \$28.2 million, according to PitchBook, and it is currently in talks with existing investors to raise a \$100 million Series A with existing investors, a person familiar with the matter told TechCrunch. The company also has received offers for over \$1 billion in incentives from two southern states if the company can build three plants over the course of 15 years, the person said.

It's a tall order for anyone to tackle, but Liss said that sort of ambition is required if the steel industry is going to deliver the sort of returns desired by venture capitalists. And, he added, basic industries like steel have historically delivered big wins for investors.

"When you look at the history of our country, many of the greatest companies that created outsize outcomes for their initial investors were in these categories," Liss said. "Ultimately, what were the Rockefellers and the Carnegies and the Melons and the Fricks investing in? The dollar amounts are so big in these categories."

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Tim De Chant is a senior climate reporter at TechCrunch. He has written for a wide range of publications, including...

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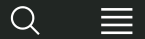
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Cocoon is transforming steel production runoff into a greener cement alternative

Brian Heater — 6:00 AM PDT · August 8, 2024

Slag is the molten runoff created while producing steel in a traditional blast furnace. The material has

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demand is only growing. Cement only makes up around 10-15% of a concrete mix, while accounting for around [90% of its emissions](#). As such, the industry is constantly searching for environmentally friendly alternatives. Cocoon is building a solution it has deemed “e-slag,” a processed bi-product of more energy-efficient steel production that serves as a cement alternative.

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IMAGE CREDITS: COCOON

“The challenge with steel slag is that it’s got a higher iron content. That’s one of the things that limits its ability to react as a cementitious material,” co-founder and CEO Eliot Brooks tells TechCrunch. “We have a two-step process that looks to address that high iron content and the challenge it creates, and also then get the cementitious reactivity at the other end of the process.”

Still in the testing phase, the U.K.-based firm’s technology is designed to slot into existing steel production workflows. The standard system involves slag pots on rails or mounted to the front of a large truck, which dump the molten material into a large pit. The slag is then allowed to cool, before being crushed up and sent off to cement producers. Cocoon’s solution is housed in a shipping container that sits in a pit, collecting the molten material as it’s poured from slag pots.

The company recently raised a \$5.4 million pre-seed. The round features Wireframe Ventures, Celsius Industries, Gigascale Capital and SOSV. The latter has been backing Cocoon for a while now, with Brooks working part-time from SOSV’s newly opened HAX facility in Newark, New Jersey. The founder was on hand when TechCrunch [toured the space back in April](#).

The new funding is being used to build an R&D facility in London. Initial tests are being conducted at a steel plant in the north of England, followed by one in the U.S. Brooks hopes Cocoon’s technology will be integrated into a pilot plant at some point in late-2025.



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Brian Heater was the Hardware Editor at TechCrunch until early 2025. He has worked for a number of leading tech...

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Electra found a cheap, clean way to purify iron, and it's raising \$257M to make it happen

Tim De Chant — 7:11 AM PST · January 3, 2025

Electra has raised \$180.4 million to clean up the dirty ironmaking industry, TechCrunch has learned. The startup has developed a novel method of using electricity to coax pure iron out of low-grade ores, opening the door to cleaner steel. The new funding round, which was disclosed in a [regulatory filing](#), seeks to raise a total of \$256.7 million.

IMAGE CREDITS:

THIANCHAI SITHTHIKONGSAK / GETTY IMAGES

Iron production today is highly polluting. It's responsible for the vast majority of emissions for steelmaking, which itself generates 7% of the world's carbon emissions. The main process used to make iron today — melting ore in searing-hot blast furnaces driven by burning fossil fuels — has remained largely unchanged for centuries.

As the industry has sought to clean up its act, it has started looking for alternatives. [Electra](#)'s solution, known as electrowinning, is already used to produce other metals like copper and nickel. Electrowinning uses an electric current to draw a metal out of a liquid solution. The metal gets plated

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Tim De Chant - Aug 1, 2025

onto an electrode while impurities drop to the bottom of the tank.

But adapting electrowinning to iron has been challenging, in part because it usually requires higher-grade ores, making the end product too expensive to compete with blast furnaces.

Electra claims that its acid-based process can handle lower-grade ores. It heats up the solution to about 60 degrees C, which is below the boiling point of water, and then sends a current through it. The resulting plates are ideal feedstock for electric-arc furnaces, which can also run on renewable energy.

When combined, electrowinning and electric-arc furnaces have the potential to eliminate the majority of steelmaking's carbon emissions.

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Electra last raised \$85 million in 2022 from investors including Amazon, Breakthrough Energy Ventures, BHP Ventures, and Nucor.

The company did not immediately reply to a request for comment.

Update: Corrected the amount raised to date.

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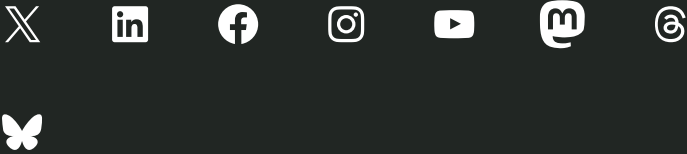
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